



ABOUT 15 YEARS ago, Sonal Giani shared her sexuality with a manager at the organisation she worked for then. The manager explicitly said the information would remain confidential, but outed her because of internal processes. “I faced a lot of backlash—graffiti in the washrooms, sexual harassment, etc. When I tried to address it without coming out, it was very difficult. I had to leave the workplace,” says the 35-year-old Senior Technical Advisor (Diversity and Inclusion) at International Planned Parenthood Federation, who identifies as a bisexual non-binary person. A few years later, she joined a hotel that positioned itself as queer-friendly; but it turned out to be an unsafe space and this pushed her into severe depression. “I thought I would not be able to work anywhere and that I’m good for nothing. I had to undergo therapy for two years.” Thanks to that and subsequent career-building roles, she has progressed in her career. Else, she would have been left with fewer economic prospects.

LGBTQ+ commitments are

ject brands and corporations who don’t really care,” says author and workplace inclusion consultant Sharif D. Rangnekar, who identifies as gay. For instance, P&G India says it reflects directly on its business results. Referring to a Vicks ad campaign called ‘Touch of Care’, which featured a transgender woman adopting children, HR Head Srinivas P.M. says the cold & flu product is a leader in its category. “Many consumers want to relate to brands that have a shared value and belief with them and that translates into the love, preference and loyalty we see for our brands.”

Saundarya Rajesh, Founder and President of D&I consulting firm Avtar Group, says “Of the companies in our Most Inclusive Companies Index 2022, 82.5 per cent have LGBTQ+ networks. Seven years ago, it would not have been [even] 25 per cent. About 70 per cent of them engage on social media with LGBTQ+ candidates to say ‘Come, we are hiring.’” Health insurance provider Plum’s Co-founder and CEO Abhishek Poddar says one in 10 companies may proactively ask for LGBTQ+ cover, but the start-up managed

To be sure, in a country where women’s participation in the labour force is at just 19 per cent and where homosexuality was decriminalised only in September 2018, very few companies are trying to be truly inclusive. A January 2022 study by HR services firm Randstad India showed that only 9.5 per cent of the surveyed organisations had made significant efforts to be LGBTQ+ inclusive, of which a majority were MNCs. Moreover, most of the conscious LGBTQ+ hirings take place at the junior (33 per cent) and middle levels (31 per cent). Ramkrishna Sinha, Co-founder of Pride Circle, which conducts job fairs for the LGBTQ+ population, says, “There is greater awareness and hence more conversions [from interviews to hiring]. But the hiring is still largely in the fresher to 5-year experience bracket.” The organisation has placed more than 750 people over the past five years and Sinha says they are seeing year-on-year growth. “IT and BFSI companies lead the hiring efforts, while full-stack developer, data analyst, business analyst, HR, admin, ops, sales and marketing are some of the roles being hired for. We also see a lot of

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growing louder in India Inc., at least on paper, driven by a younger and more socially aware consumer and talent pool. “Corporates are waking up to the fact that these are my consumers too and the talent I might be hiring. They are becoming more and more conscious that they may re-

to counsel about 90 per cent of its customer base to include it. “The group medical cover can now be extended to same-sex or live-in partners and can include gender-reassignment surgeries that were earlier not covered because they were considered cosmetic procedures,” he adds.

Indian origin companies engaging with LGBTQ+ talent,” he adds.

But, as Giani’s example proves, bungled attempts do more harm than good. “Quite often, organisations are not prepared. A lot of corporations fail to bring in cultural change. They tend to limit it to a policy, a day or a month,”